



▲ PERSEPOLIS

In 518 BCE, Darius I founded a new capital, Persepolis, where he built a vast palace. During Nowruz, the annual spring festival, people from all over the empire brought gifts to Persepolis. The city was burned down by Alexander the Great in 330 BCE.

DARIUS I

The third of the Persian Empire's great kings, Darius I (reigned 522–486 BCE) was a gifted leader. He improved his empire's organization and completed many building projects. Though he expanded the empire to its greatest extent, he failed to conquer the Greek city-states.



The Persian Empire

In the 6th century BCE, Cyrus II, king of the small city-state of Persis (in modern-day Iran), began a series of conquests that led to the creation of the world's first superpower. At its peak, the Persian Empire he founded controlled territories in Africa, Asia, and Europe.

A brilliant military commander, Cyrus the Great—as he came to be called—conquered three neighboring empires over a period of just 11 years. Though ferocious in battle, he was generous toward those he defeated, and allowed people in the captured territories to retain their religions, beliefs, and customs. After his death, his son Cambyses II expanded the empire by conquering Egypt. The empire reached its peak under Darius I who extended its territory into Europe. The empire received tributes (gifts, such as gold)

from the conquered territories, and punished any rebellion swiftly.

There was a long rivalry between the Persians and their western neighbors, the Greeks, and in 330 BCE the Persian Empire eventually fell to the massive army of Alexander the Great (see p.27). Following Alexander's conquest, there were two later Persian empires, the Parthian and Sasanian, the latter of which was defeated by Arab invaders in 642 CE.

CONNECTING THE EMPIRE ►

The Persian Empire was better run and better connected than any previous empire. Each province was run by a powerful satrap (governor), who was allowed to make decisions independent of the king. Darius I developed a new postal system, and built new roads to connect the empire—the most important was the Royal Road, which connected his capital, Susa, with the Mediterranean coast. People rode in chariots, much like this model of a satrap's vehicle.

